

(Usually this went directly to my rent and bills.) Our agent took 10 percent. These opportunities were few and far between. I still had no savings or a cushion in case of an emergency. I started driving for Postmates, a food delivery app. To get a job there, I showed up at a very long and boring training session in downtown LA. I was one of probably fifty people there, all desperate to participate in the gig economy for peanuts on the dollar. I felt faceless and worthless. But it was lucky I even had the option of doing this kind of job.

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Many, many job-seekers feel the same way. The gig economy has been thriving over the past ten years. In 2016, the Pew Research Center reported that almost 25 percent of Americans made money on a digital earning platform, like Airbnb or Lyft, that year. Thirty-seven percent said that like me, it filled gaps in their employment, 17 percent said it was because of a lack of other available jobs, and 15 percent said they needed the flexible schedule because of other obligations.

Though taking gigs is not new, the phenomenon has exploded with the introduction of apps. The percentage of Americans in the gig economy is “expected to be 43% by the year 2020,” Intuit CEO Brad Smith said in May 2017.

The gig economy boom can be linked to the normalization of the “side hustle.” (Warning: Googling “side hustle” leads to some truly disturbing auto-fills like “illegal side hustle” and “side hustles for nurses or teachers.” The former is disturbing for obvious reasons and the latter because those are jobs that should pay enough.)

Past generations may have taken on extra work to save for a specific expense or splurge, but Bankrate reported in 2017 that 61 percent of current young people say they earn and use their side hustle money every week. Meanwhile, the Freelancers Union and Upwork predicted all kinds of freelancers will make up a majority of the U.S. workforce within a decade. This is very different from yesteryear’s forty years at one company and then a gold watch and a pension.

While these gigs are lifesavers for many people or even just passion projects, I am skeptical of the increased normalization of needing to overwork yourself in